

THE YEAR OF UNTIED KNOTS

BOOK 1 OF 12

The Nine Knots

Nine knots, held.

FATHER LUCAS · AUGSBURG

DEDICATION

For you, who finished the nine nights, woke up in the same house, and kept going anyway.



Father Lucas



BOOK 1

This book: The nine knots of the novena, three mornings each, in the same order: health, money, marriage, the one who left, children, work, forgiveness, peace, surrender.

How it goes: Name it. Hand it to Mary. Keep it loose. Then three days to look back, write the first names, and light the first candle.

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

1. **The verse.** Read it slowly, out loud if you can.
2. **The word.** A short reading, about one minute.
3. **The prayer.** Say it as written, or in your own words.
4. **Today.** One small thing to do, a question to answer on the lines, and a box to tick when it's done.

If you miss a morning, don't catch up.
Turn to today's page and begin again.
Keep a pen beside this book and write in it.
These pages are yours.

A LETTER FROM FATHER LUCAS

Good morning, my friend.

You finished the nine nights. I want you to know that was not small. Most people never finish anything they start in the dark.

This month we walk the same nine knots again, slowly, three mornings each. First we name it. Then we hand it to Mary. Then we find one small habit that keeps it loose.

It's three minutes. A page, a prayer, one small thing to do with your hands.

I can't promise what will untie, or when. I can promise you won't do it alone. Pour the coffee. Turn the page.

Father Lucas

THE MONTH IN FOUR WEEKS



- **Week 1:** Health, money, and the marriage that went cold. We name what hurts and stop pretending it doesn't.
- **Week 2:** The one who left, the children, and the work that ended. We learn to hand over what we cannot carry.
- **Week 3:** Forgiveness, then peace. We unclench the hand and let the dark room hold a candle.
- **Week 4:** Surrender, then looking back, your Names Page, and the first candle.

BOOK I

THREE PROMISES FOR THIS MONTH

I. *I will open the page before I open the news.*

II. *I will say what is true, even if it is small.*

III. *If I miss a morning, I will begin again, not give up.*

IV. --

MY NAME



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WEEK 1

Health, money, and the marriage that went cold

DAYS 1 TO 7

We name what hurts and stop pretending it doesn't.



DAY 1

The Ache Has a Name



He heals the broken in heart,
and binds up their wounds.

PSALM 147:3 (WEB)

Good morning, my friend. You finished the nine nights, and you woke up in the same house, in the same body. That's the hard part, and I won't pretend otherwise.

Today we start with health. We're not fixing anything yet. We're saying it, plainly, the way you'd tell a doctor you really trust.

Here's what I've seen. A worry kept in the head goes round and round like a coin in the dryer. Once it's said out loud, it sits still. And Mary doesn't need the long version. She has sat beside beds. She isn't afraid of what you're afraid of.

Mother Mary, here is my body, tired as it is. Here is the pain, and here is the worry I carry for someone I love. I'm not hiding either one today. Stay with me at the appointment, in the waiting room, and in the long hour before sleep. Loosen the fear first. Then whatever else you will. Amen.



TODAY

Write one line: the thing about your health that scares you most. Fold the paper small and tuck it under your rosary or your Bible.

☐ DONE

What have I been calling "fine" that is not fine?

PSALM

147 — he binds up wounds; the psalm for a body and a heart that both hurt.



DAY 2

Mary at the Bedside



Have mercy on me, LORD, for I am faint. LORD, heal me, for my bones are troubled. My soul is also in great anguish. But you, LORD—how long?

PSALM 6:2–3 (WEB)

You said it out loud yesterday, or you tried. Now comes the harder part: letting go of it. Not for good. Just for the length of this page.

Think of the last time you sat by a bed. Your mother's, maybe. Your own. Mary has sat through more of those nights than you and I ever will. She didn't fix a thing. She also never left.

So hand her the worry the way you'd hand someone your coat at the door. Handing it over isn't dropping it. She'll hold it while you sit down.

Mary, you know what it is to sit and wait. I'm tired of waiting alone. Take this body, this appointment, this long list of what-ifs. I can't carry them down the hall today. Walk beside me. Let one kind word come from a nurse, a neighbor, or you. And if the news is hard, stay in the room. Amen.



TODAY

Say out loud, in your own kitchen voice, "I'm tired, and I'm still here." Then say the name of the one who is sick, even if that one is you.

☐ DONE

Who has been sitting beside me this whole time without being asked?

PSALM

6 — faint and worn out? Ask for mercy plainly; the psalm doesn't dress it up.



DAY 3

The Pill Box and the Prayer

For his anger is but for a moment. His favor is for a lifetime. Weeping may stay for the night, but joy comes in the morning.

PSALM 30:5 (WEB)

Marguerite sings in our choir, and she cares for her husband at home. She tied a bit of ribbon to the lid of his pill box. Every time she opens it, she says one Hail Mary before the first pill. "I forget everything now," she told me. "The pill box doesn't."

That's the trick. You don't have to remember to pray. You hang the prayer on something you already do without thinking: the pills, the glass of water, the coffeepot.

Then the knot has one more hand holding it loose every morning, and you never had to try.

Lord Jesus, thank you for the small routine that gets me out of bed. Bless the hands that fill this box, and the doctors who wrote the list. Let each morning start with you before it starts with the ache. Give me patience with the schedule, and peace on the days I forget. Stay through all of today's hours, the easy ones and the long ones. Amen.



TODAY

Set your rosary or a small holy card beside your pill box or your morning glass of water. Each time you reach for it, say, "Mary, stay."

☐ DONE

What do I do every morning without thinking that could carry a prayer?

PSALM

30 — weeping may stay for the night, but joy comes in the morning.



DAY 4

The Number You Won't Say

Save me, God, for the waters have come up to my neck! I sink in deep mire, where there is no foothold. I have come into deep waters, where the floods overflow me.

PSALM 69:1–2 (WEB)

There's a number you don't say out loud. You know the one. It lives on the envelope, or the screen, or somewhere behind your eyes at three in the morning.

Fear loves a number with no name. It grows in the dark like mold in a cupboard. A number written down is just a number. It has edges. It fits on a card, and a card fits in a pocket, where it weighs almost nothing.

I'm not asking you to solve it. Look at it in daylight, with your coffee, and Mary at your elbow.

It's early, and the number's already in the room with me. Here it is, Lord. I won't hide it in a drawer today. You see every dollar I owe and every dollar I'm short. Hold the number steady while I look at it. Give me courage for the next envelope, and enough sleep tonight to face it. Amen.



TODAY

Write the real number on a card. Not the smaller one you tell your children. Slide the card under your coffee cup, and look at it once.

☐ DONE

If a friend told me this number, what would I say to her?

PSALM

69 — the waters up to my neck; the prayer of the overwhelmed.



DAY 5

Mary Counted Every Coin



Better is a little that the righteous has, than the abundance of many wicked.

PSALM 37:16 (WEB)

Mary was poor. Not poor in a stained-glass way. A carpenter's house in a small town. She knew the weight of a single coin in a small hand.

So when you tell her you're afraid of the grocery total, she doesn't need it explained. She has stood at the market stall and added it up twice, hoping she'd made a mistake.

Poor people have always known how to pray. Hunger teaches it fast. She won't scold you for it. She'll ask for one worry at a time. Start with the smallest one today.

Mary, you counted coins with hands like mine. Look at the ones in my wallet, the ones I owe, and the ones I wish I had. I give you all three. Teach me to be thankful for what's on the table today, and calm about what isn't. Walk with me to the store. Keep my voice steady at the register. Amen.



TODAY

Hold one coin in your palm. Say, "Give us this day our daily bread," and then, "Mary, count with me." Slip the coin into your pocket.

☐ DONE

What do I already have today that I forgot to count?

PSALM

37 — a little with God is more than a lot without him.



DAY 6

One Bill at a Time

Why should I fear in the days of evil, when iniquity at my heels surrounds me?

PSALM 49:5 (WEB)

Last winter Eileen showed me a cookie tin full of unopened envelopes. Her husband used to handle them. After he died, she couldn't look. "If I don't open it, it can't be worse," she said.

We sat at her table. She opened one. Only one. It was smaller than she feared. She cried anyway, and then she put the coffee on.

A pile feels like a hundred problems. It's usually four, and two of them are the same. Fear works on the pile. Prayer works on one page. Open the next one, read it slowly, and let the rest wait their turn.

Lord, I've been afraid of paper. Give me steady hands today. Let me open what I've been avoiding and read what it really says. Where I'm confused, send me someone patient to explain. Where I'm wrong, let me say so without shame. One person, one pile. I trust you with the order of it. Amen.



TODAY

Put your bills in one pile, most urgent on top. Open only the top one and read it. Then stop, and say a Hail Mary.

☐ DONE

Which envelope do I keep stepping around on my way to the kitchen?

PSALM

49 — why should I fear? A psalm for when the hard days crowd in.



DAY 7

What Went Cold

If a man prevails against one who is alone, two shall withstand him; and a threefold cord is not quickly broken.

ECCLESIASTES 4:12 (WEB)

Something went cold in this house. You know when. Maybe one harsh word, or a hundred small silences. Maybe nothing happened at all, and the chair across from you is empty, and the cold is only the quiet.

Most marriages don't break on the big fight. They cool on small things, like the morning nobody said, "See you tonight."

The old verse calls a marriage a cord of three strands: two people and God. When one strand frays or is gone, the others still hold. Today we only name the frayed one. Gently. Blaming no one.

Lord Jesus, you were at the wedding. You know what a marriage is made of, and what wears it thin. I name the cold place today. I'm not blaming, and I'm not hiding. If my husband or wife is here, soften us both. If they're gone, hold the love that has nowhere to go. Warm what you can. Amen.



TODAY

Write two lines to your husband or wife, living or gone. Put the note in an envelope. Tomorrow, decide whether to send it or keep it.

☐ DONE

When did we last laugh at the same thing?

PSALM

45 — a wedding song; remember the day you said yes.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

A marriage warms the way a house does, one small fire at a time. Skip a week of praying for it and the cold creeps back into the corners. Come back tomorrow. It only takes three minutes.



WEEK 2

Week 2

DAYS 8 TO 14

The one who left, the children, and the work that ended. We learn to hand over what we cannot carry.



DAY 8

The Wine at Cana

When the wine ran out, Jesus' mother said to him, "They have no wine."

JOHN 2:3 (WEB)

At a wedding in Cana, the wine ran out. The host didn't know yet. The guests didn't know. Mary knew. She made no speech. She leaned toward her Son and said four words: "They have no wine."

Notice what she left out. No plan. No advice. She said what was missing and trusted him with the rest.

You can pray like that. Tell her what has run out. Patience. Tenderness. Small talk at supper. She'll lean over and say it for you. Then you wait. Mary is very good at waiting, my friend.

Mary of Cana, you noticed what ran out before anyone said a word. Notice it now in my home. The patience is gone, the kindness is thin, and I'm too tired to refill it myself. Lean over and tell your Son. Whatever he says to me today, let me do it, even if it is small. Amen.



TODAY

Say out loud, "They have no wine." Then name the one thing that has run out between you and your husband or wife. Once, quietly, to the room.

☐ DONE

What did we have in our very first year that I'd most like back?

PSALM

55 — cast your burden on the Lord, when the hurt comes from someone close.



DAY 9

The First Soft Word

A gentle answer turns away wrath, but a harsh word stirs up anger.

PROVERBS 15:1 (WEB)

Walt ushered at our church door for thirty years. He told me his wife had stopped hearing "You look nice" somewhere around their fortieth anniversary. One morning, while she poured the coffee, he said it anyway. She looked at him as if he'd spoken French.

"Walt, are you sick?" "No," he said. "Just late."

She laughed. The kitchen changed. That evening he dried the pans without being asked, and she noticed. Neither of them said a word.

A gentle word is small, and it works. It won't fix forty years. It opens a window in them.

Gentle Mother, some mornings my tongue is sharp, and some mornings it's silent. Put one soft word in my mouth today, and make me brave enough to say it. Keep me from the last word, the clever word, the cold word. Let someone in this house, or in my memory of it, feel a little warmer because of me. Amen.



TODAY

Rest a hand on your husband's or wife's shoulder, or on the back of the chair they sat in. Say one soft word, like "thank you."

☐ DONE

What soft word am I waiting for them to say first?

PSALM

85 — mercy and truth meet; righteousness and peace have kissed.

10

DAY 10

The Name That Hurts to Say

I waited patiently for the LORD. He turned to me, and heard my cry.

PSALM 40:1 (WEB)

There's a name you skip. You leave it out of your prayers. You step around it at family dinners. When somebody says it, your chest goes tight.

Maybe a son. A sister. A friend of fifty years. They left, or you did, or it happened slowly, the way a tide goes out and you only notice the wet sand.

Today you write the name down. Not to fix anything. Just to stop pretending there's no hole. Mary knows the weight of a name. She said her Son's every day of her life. You don't have to stop saying yours.

Lord, here is the name I find hard to say. You've never forgotten it, not for one hour. I put it in your hands, with the quarrel, the silence, the guilt, and the love underneath all of it. I don't know what to ask, except this: keep them safe, and keep my heart open. Do the part I can't. Amen.



TODAY

Write that name on a slip of paper, small if you have to. Put the slip where you'll see it, and say the name aloud once.

☐ DONE

If they called today, what is the first thing I would say?

PSALM

40 — I waited patiently, and he turned to me and heard my cry.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

Somewhere, someone may be carrying your name the way you carry theirs. Whether you reach out or only pray, keep that name in front of you. A name you stop saying goes cold. Say it again tomorrow.



DAY 11

The Mother Who Searched



When they saw him, they were astonished; and his mother said to him, "Son, why have you treated us this way? Behold, your father and I were anxiously looking for you."

LUKE 2:48 (WEB)

The boy was twelve when he went missing, and his parents didn't notice for a whole day's walk. Picture Mary's face when she counted heads and he wasn't there. Then the three days after that. Every street. Every stranger. "Have you seen a boy?"

She found him in the last place she thought to look. And see how she greets him: not calm, worn out, a little sharp. A searching mother is allowed to be.

If someone you love is missing from your life, you're searching too. In the kitchen, on your phone, in your sleep. Light a candle and let her search with you.

Mary, you walked the streets looking for your Son. I'm walking mine, in my mind, in the night. Go ahead of me. Look where I can't. Put your hand on their shoulder and turn them gently toward home. And when I'm too tired to keep searching, let me rest in you. I'll keep this little flame lit. Amen.



TODAY

Light a candle for someone who doesn't know you're praying. Say their name once. Let it burn while you finish your coffee.

☐ DONE

Where have I stopped looking for them, and why did I stop?

PSALM

60 — lost ground; when you have run out of places to search, ask for help.

12

DAY 12

The Door Left Unlatched

From the end of the earth, I will call to you when my heart is overwhelmed. Lead me to the rock that is higher than I.

PSALM 61:2 (WEB)

I let a whole year go by without calling my sister. No fight. It just slid, and then it got awkward, and then it got heavy. I rehearsed the call in the shower and never made it. When I finally dialed, she picked up on the second ring and said, "I wondered when."

People come back more often than we think. They don't always knock. They check whether the door's still unlatched. Sometimes they only slow down outside, to see if the curtains are open.

So today we leave it unlatched. Not with worry. With welcome.

Holy Mother, I leave a door open today. Not the one in the wall. The one in me. If they call, let me answer gently and not say "finally." If they write, let me read it with kind eyes. If they come to the step and stand there, give me one good sentence. Until then, I wait with a lighter heart. Amen.



TODAY

Open a window for one minute and let the house breathe. While it's open, say, "The door is open." Then close it and go on with your morning.

☐ DONE

What would I need to hear first to pick up the phone?

PSALM

61 — from the end of the earth I call; for anyone far from home.

13

DAY 13

Who You Carry

Keep me as the apple of your eye. Hide me under the shadow of your wings,

PSALM 17:8 (WEB)

Count them on your fingers. The ones you raised, and the ones who came after. A boy in another state. A girl with a baby of her own. A grandson who stopped answering your texts. A grandchild whose face you know only from a phone.

You carry every one. Some are gray now and still your children. You carry them in the grocery line and at the sink, and nobody asked you to.

Today, don't fix anyone. Call the roll, slowly, and let each one be named before God. Notice who you name first. That tells you where the worry sits.

Lord Jesus, here are my children and theirs. You know them better than I do, even the ones who feel like strangers now. Keep them in the shadow of your wings. Give them good friends and honest work. Bring them safely through each day, and bring me peace when I can't see them. They belong to you before they belong to me. Amen.



TODAY

Say the names of your family in order of age, slowly. Say each one the way you'd introduce them to a friend you trust.

☐ DONE

Which one do I worry about when I could be praying?

PSALM

17 — keep them as the apple of your eye, hidden in your wings.

14

DAY 14

Under the Blue Mantle

May God be merciful to us, bless us, and cause his face to shine on us. Selah.

PSALM 67:1 (WEB)

Picture the mantle. Blue, wide, heavy as a good wool coat. Mary holds it open. The old pictures show it big enough to cover whole towns. It will certainly cover your children, and theirs.

Now picture each one stepping under it. The oldest first. The one who won't talk about God. The little one with the cough. You don't push them. You only point. There's plenty of room, and no list of conditions.

You can't follow them to school, to work, or to bed. She can. That's the whole prayer today.

Mother Mary, spread your mantle over my children. I say their names, one by one, and place them under it. Cover the ones who are far. Cover the ones who are angry with me. Cover the ones who don't know they need it. Keep them from harm I cannot see. Bring them home to joy, however long the road. Amen.



TODAY

Say today's prayer once more, this time looking at a photograph of your children or grandchildren. Take your time on each face.

☐ DONE

What do I most want them to know that I've never said?

PSALM

67 — a family blessing; may his face shine on us.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

Praying for your children isn't a wall you build once. It's a tide you meet each morning. The same tide that tied the knot is still out there. Come back tomorrow and stand in it again.



WEEK 3

Forgiveness, then peace

DAYS 15 TO 21

We unclench the hand and let the dark room hold a candle.

15

DAY 15

The Blessing at the Door

‘the LORD bless you, and keep you. The LORD make his face to shine on you, and be gracious to you. The LORD lift up his face toward you, and give you peace.’

NUMBERS 6:24–26 (WEB)

Mrs. Doyle has cleaned our church for twenty years, and she has a habit she never explains. Whenever one of her grandchildren leaves her house, she stands at the door and makes a small cross in the air with her thumb. Then she says, "Go on."

They roll their eyes. They also, every one of them, wait for it.

A blessing doesn't have to be loud. It has to be said, at the door, with love, every time. That's the part that stays. Years from now they won't remember what she cooked. They'll remember the thumb.

Gentle Mother, I bless them as they go. Under your mantle in the morning, under your mantle at night. Let them go out with your peace on them, and come back with it still there. I can't walk them to every corner, but I can stand at this door and say, Go with God. Hear it, Mary, and carry it for me. Amen.



TODAY

Make the Sign of the Cross slowly over a photograph of a child or grandchild. Say quietly, "The Lord bless you and keep you."

☐ DONE

Who in my family has never heard me bless them aloud?

PSALM

78 — tell the next generation; a grandparent's psalm.



DAY 16

The Closed Door

He will be like a tree planted by the streams of water, that produces its fruit in its season, whose leaf also does not wither. Whatever he does shall prosper.

PSALM 1:3 (WEB)

It might be a job that ended on a bad day. A career that quietly stopped needing you. A house you couldn't keep. Or the quiet of a retirement you didn't plan for, when nobody needs you at ten in the morning.

A door has closed, and you can still hear it. Don't tell yourself it didn't matter. Don't tell yourself it was the end of you.

Today we only name it. Which door? Who were you on the other side of it? What did it feel like to be needed there? Say it honestly, and then we'll see what's still standing.

Lord, a door closed in my life, and I'm still standing in the hall. I miss what was on the other side. I miss being needed. I won't pretend I'm fine, and I won't pretend I'm finished. Show me, in your own time, one small honest thing my hands can still do. Until then, keep me from bitterness. Amen.



TODAY

Write one sentence that begins, "What I miss most about that work is..." Finish it honestly, and read it aloud once.

☐ DONE

What part of me was never in that job, and is still here?

PSALM

1 — a tree by the water; roots that don't depend on the job.

17

DAY 17

Joseph's Workshop

Let the favor of the Lord our God be on us. Establish the work of our hands for us. Yes, establish the work of our hands.

PSALM 90:17 (WEB)

Joseph was a carpenter. Not a king, not a scholar. A man with sawdust in his hair who made doors and tables and yokes. The Son of God learned from him how to hold a plane.

Think about that. Heaven stood at a workbench and learned a trade slowly, one crooked board at a time. Nothing was beneath it. At the end of the day, he swept up the shavings like any honest man.

Whatever your hands have done, bring it here. The ledger, the lunch pail, the garden, a grandchild's scraped knee. Honest work, at any age, is love you can see.

Saint Joseph, and Mary who lived beside you, pray for my hands. Bless what they have built, mended, cooked, and carried. Bless what they can still do, however small. Let me never think of myself as finished while I can set one board on another. Make my work today honest, and my rest honest too. Amen.



TODAY

Clear one square foot of a counter. Set one thing there that your hands made or fixed. Stand and look at it for ten slow breaths.

☐ DONE

What have my hands made that I forgot to be proud of?

PSALM

90 — establish the work of our hands; a prayer for a worker of any age.



DAY 18

Knock Again Tomorrow



Ask, and it will be given you. Seek, and you will find. Knock, and it will be opened for you.

MATTHEW 7:7 (WEB)

Knocking isn't a feeling. It's a motion. You raise your hand, you rap three times, and you wait.

Some doors you've knocked on already. Some you haven't dared. At sixty or seventy it can feel foolish. Who wants an old hand on the door? But a knock costs nothing. It takes a phone and a little nerve. Behind every desk is a person, and people often answer to kindness.

Pray first, then knock. Not to force the door open, but to keep your heart from closing while you wait. One call today. Just one.

Lord Jesus, you told me to knock, so I'm knocking. Not loudly. Only steadily. Give me the right words on the phone, and patience when the answer is no. Let me hear any kindness that is offered, and let me recognize an opening when it is small. Walk through the door ahead of me, and I'll follow. Amen.



TODAY

Call one office, shop, or neighbor you've been putting off, and ask for one answer. Write down the name of the person and what they say.

☐ DONE

What small thing would I try if I stopped being afraid of "no"?

PSALM

119 — your word is a lamp to my feet; light for the next step only.



DAY 19

The Sentence in Your Chest

Lord, all my desire is before you. My groaning is not hidden from you.

PSALM 38:9 (WEB)

There's a sentence that lives in your chest. "She never apologized." "He chose her over me." "I should have known." You've said it so often it's worn a groove, like the path across a lawn.

It's heavy, and it's yours. You may even be right. I'm not here to argue.

But a sentence stuck in the chest is a knot. It doesn't loosen by pretending it isn't there. It loosens when it's said once, in plain words, to someone who won't argue back. Notice where it sits, and how old the voice sounds. Today you say it to Mary, out loud, in your own voice.

Mary, here is the sentence I keep repeating. You've heard worse, and you were still gentle. I'm tired of carrying it. I'm not ready to let it go, so I ask you to hold it with me. Help me want to be free of it. Give me tomorrow the strength I don't have today. Amen.



TODAY

Write the sentence exactly as it sits in your chest. Don't soften it. Then read it once, aloud, and fold the paper in half.

☐ DONE

If this sentence were true and forgiven, what would be left?

PSALM

38 — my groaning is not hidden from you; the psalm for a hurt that has no words.

20

DAY 20

Mary Beneath the Cross

Jesus said, "Father, forgive them, for they don't know what they are doing." Dividing his garments among them, they cast lots.

LUKE 23:34 (WEB)

She stood there. The Gospel says so in just that way: she stood. She didn't faint, and she didn't shout. Her Son was dying, and she was near enough to hear him breathe. And then she heard him say, "Father, forgive them."

Think of a mother's heart. Those were the men who had done it. And he asked pardon for them while she listened.

She didn't answer with a speech. She taught by standing. You don't have to forgive today. You only have to stand near the One who can.

Mother who stood, stand with me. I'm not ready to say the words. I only ask to be near the One who said them. Keep me from hardening, keep me from pretending, and keep me from turning away. Teach me to forgive the way you stood: slowly, quietly, and without leaving. Let a little mercy in, even through a crack. Amen.



TODAY

Sit with your coffee and say nothing for two full minutes. Let the name of the one who hurt you rise, and let it sit there.

☐ DONE

What would it cost me to stand near mercy for one more day?

PSALM

25 — remember your mercy, not my old mistakes; for old regrets and old wounds.



DAY 21

One Hand Unclenched

I acknowledged my sin to you. I didn't hide my iniquity. I said, I will confess my transgressions to the LORD, and you forgave the iniquity of my sin. Selah.

PSALM 32:5 (WEB)

Mrs. Doyle once held a dishcloth in her fist through most of a funeral lunch. I noticed when she finally set it down. Her knuckles were white. "I didn't know I was doing that," she said.

We hold grudges the same way. Not in the mind, in the hand. We don't know we're gripping until someone points.

Look at your own hands now, while you read. Is one of them tight? Open it, a little. You don't have to give the grudge away today. You only have to let the blood come back.

Lord, I've been gripping. I didn't know how hard until now. I'm opening one hand, a little, and I'm asking you to put something kinder in it. I don't forgive everything today. I forgive this much: I'll stop squeezing. Soothe the ache where the grip was. Fill that space with something gentle, even if it's only quiet. Amen.



TODAY

Rest both hands palm-up on your lap for one full minute. Notice which one wants to close. Let it stay open.

☐ DONE

What am I holding so tightly that my hand has forgotten it?

PSALM

32 — blessed is the one whose sin is forgiven; the lightness after you put it down.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

I let a grudge sit for three winters once, because letting go felt like losing. It grew. Come back tomorrow, please. Forgiveness isn't one big moment. It's a hand opened again each morning.



WEEK 4

Week 4

DAYS 22 TO 30

Surrender, then looking back, your Names Page, and the first candle.

22

DAY 22

The Heaviness at Dawn

But you, LORD, are a shield around me, my glory, and the one who lifts up my head.

PSALM 3:3 (WEB)

You wake, and before you've opened your eyes, it's there. The weight. Like a coat someone laid over you in the night. Nothing has happened yet. The day hasn't started, and still your chest is tired.

Some mornings are like this. But heaviness at dawn is not a verdict on the day. It's weather, and weather moves. Before you reach for the phone or the news, let your feet find the floor. The bad news will keep. It always does.

Then lift your head, the way the psalm says God lifts it, and look at the window.

Lord, the day is here and I'm already tired. Lift my head, as you promised. Not my whole life, only my head, only this morning. Be a shield around me while I stand up, start the coffee, and face the first small chore. I'll take it one thing at a time. Be with me in each one. Amen.



TODAY

Look out a window for one minute with your phone in another room. Say nothing. Let the light come into the room.

☐ DONE

What always feels lighter once the sun is fully up?

PSALM

3 — you lift up my head; the first psalm for a heavy morning.



DAY 23

A Light in the Dark Room



In peace I will both lay myself down and sleep, for you alone, LORD, make me live in safety.

PSALM 4:8 (WEB)

Put out the lamp, and the room becomes a different place. Every sound is bigger. Every thought has teeth. At our age the night runs long. The body wakes at two, and the mind wakes right behind it. Many of you tell me the dark is the worst part, because there's nothing to do with your hands.

So give them something. A candle. One flame shows you the chair, the cup, the edge of the table. It doesn't chase every shadow. It only reminds you that you're in a room, not in a pit.

Light it, say the psalm slowly, and rest.

Mary, Mother of the quiet hours, I light this small flame for you. Be with me in the dark rooms of my house and my head. Take the noise out of the corners. Let me see ordinary things for what they are: a chair, a cup, a window. Bring me peace tonight, and a sleep that does not frighten me. Amen.



TODAY

Light a candle and count ten breaths while you watch the flame. When your mind wanders, bring it back with the word "Mary."

☐ DONE

What looks smaller to me by candlelight than it did by lamplight?

PSALM

4 — in peace I will lie down and sleep; the psalm for a restless bed.



DAY 24

One Small Good Thing

LORD, in the morning you will hear my voice. In the morning I will lay my requests before you, and will watch expectantly.

PSALM 5:3 (WEB)

Eileen told me she started a game after her husband died. Each day she walked to Sal's store on the corner and found one good thing. A ripe pear. A kind word. A cat asleep in the window. She told no one. She just noticed.

"It isn't joy," she said. "It's a doorknob." Something to hold on to when the door is stuck.

You don't need a big good thing. You need a small one, and an eye open for it. The Lord listens in the morning. Watch for the answer, however plain.

Lord, I bring my requests in the morning, as the psalm says. And I'll watch. Open my eyes to the small good things I walk past: light on the floor, a neighbor's wave, a warm cup. Teach me to be glad of crumbs until I can be glad of bread. Thank you for this day, rough as it is. Amen.



TODAY

Walk to the mailbox slowly. On the way, find one small good thing. When you're back inside, write it on a scrap of paper.

☐ DONE

What good thing did I almost miss yesterday?

PSALM

5 — in the morning I will lay my requests before you and watch.

25

DAY 25

Nine Knots in Open Hands

Trust in him at all times, you people. Pour out your heart before him. God is a refuge for us. Selah.

PSALM 62:8 (WEB)

Nine knots. You've named them. You've handed them over. Now I'd like you to do something simple, with your body.

Make two fists. Hold them tight, the way you've held all of this. Feel your shoulders go up. Feel your jaw.

Now open. Slowly. Palms up, like you're asking for rain. Let the air go out with the open hands, and let your shoulders come down an inch.

That's it. That's the whole of surrender. Not giving up. Not deciding it doesn't matter. Only opening the hand, so Someone can take what's in it.

Here, Lord. Here is my health, my money, my marriage, the one who left, my children, my work, my grudges, my fear, and my tomorrow. I can't hold them all, and I never could. Take them from my hands, one knot at a time, in your own order. Mary, undo what only you can undo. I'm resting my arms. Amen.



TODAY

Make two fists for five seconds. Then open them, palms up, on your lap. Say, "Nine knots, open hands."

☐ DONE

Which of my hands was slower to open, and what was it holding?

PSALM

62 — pour out your heart before him; God is a refuge for us.



DAY 26

Thank Her Before You See It

I will give thanks to the LORD with my whole heart. I will tell of all your marvelous works.

PSALM 9:1 (WEB)

Thanks that comes after the answer is easy. Anyone can say it. The thanks that counts is the one you say before.

It sounds strange. Why thank her for what you haven't seen? Because trust is just thanks that arrives early. It's like thanking the neighbor who's already put on her coat to come help you.

You've given Mary nine knots. She's no stranger. Try it once, in your own words, and listen to how it sounds. Plain and warm, the way you'd say it to a friend already coming up the walk.

Mary, thank you. I haven't seen a single knot loosen yet, and I'm thanking you anyway. Thank you for listening, for coming in, for staying a while. I don't know what comes next, but I know who's here. Mary, keep my thanks honest and simple, and let it grow in me slowly as the days go by. Amen.



TODAY

Say "thank you" out loud to three things in the room, such as the chair, the lamp, and the window. Then say it to her.

☐ DONE

What am I ready to thank her for, before I see it?

PSALM

9 — I will give thanks with my whole heart; praise that comes before the answer.



DAY 27

Why Knots Come Back

Those who know your name will put their trust in you, for you, LORD, have not forsaken those who seek you.

PSALM 9:10 (WEB)

Father Matthias gave me this book, and he told me something I've never forgotten. "A knot isn't a mistake, Lucas. It's what thread does." Thread tangles if nobody tends it.

That's why we pray each morning. Not because we're weak. Because that's how life ties itself. Worry comes back. Old quarrels come back. They're not enemies. They're weather.

So build a habit that doesn't need strength: one place where the prayer waits for you, tired or not. A plain kitchen chair is enough. The worn spot on the cushion does half the praying for you.

Lord, I know the knots may come back. I'm not afraid of that today. I only ask for a place to meet you each morning, a small one, simple enough for tired days. Help me keep it. Help me return when I miss it, without shame. You have not forsaken those who seek you. I'm seeking. Amen.



TODAY

Tape today's prayer to the bathroom mirror, or set this book where your eyes land first in the morning. Read it once there.

☐ DONE

Where could this prayer wait for me every single morning?

PSALM

9 — you have not forsaken those who seek you.



DAY 28

Looking Back at the Nine

The LORD has done great things for us, and we are glad.

PSALM 126:3 (WEB)

Twenty-eight mornings. Look at them. Not all of them went well. Maybe you skipped one, or three. Maybe you cried through two. Maybe you did the dishes during the prayer.

That's all right. A thread doesn't care how it got looser. It only matters that it did, even a little.

Look back at the nine: health, money, marriage, the one who left, the children, work, forgiveness, peace, surrender. Which one moved, even a little? Which one only stopped being a secret? If you missed days and feel ashamed, write to Sister Camille. She answers every letter.

Mary, I look back at these weeks and I see the ones I wanted to be different. I also see the ones that changed. I don't need a sign to be grateful. I need only your hand, even where I couldn't feel it. Thank you for walking me through the first nine. Take me into the next, steady and unhurried. Amen.



TODAY

Write today's date and one thing that has changed, even slightly, since the first morning. Put the paper where you will see it.

☐ DONE

Which of the nine is even a little looser than before?

PSALM

126 — the Lord has done great things for us; the psalm for looking back.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

Looking back is not the same as being done. Today's grace is today's bread, and tomorrow's isn't baked tonight. Open tomorrow's page, and ask for what you need in the morning.



DAY 29

Your Names Page

Behold, I have engraved you on the palms of my hands. Your walls are continually before me.

ISAIAH 49:16 (WEB)

Somewhere in your book is a page for names. Find it. It's plain, with lines. It's been waiting for yours.

Why a page? Because prayers drift. Names don't. A name written down is one you can't forget to pray for. It's a thread tied to the page.

Write the living first. Then the ones who've passed. Then the ones you've lost touch with. And at the bottom, the name that's hardest to write. A shaky hand is part of the prayer.

God did the same. He says he has you engraved on the palms of his hands.

Lord, here are the names I carry. I write them with a shaking hand, and I give them to you with a steady one. You know them already. Keep each one close tonight, the way you keep me. Where a name hurts, be gentle. Where a name is missing, remind me. Let this page be a doorway between us. Amen.



TODAY

Take your Names Page and write the first three names that come to you. Don't think too long. Write, and say each one aloud.

☐ DONE

Whose name did I write first, and what does that tell me?

PSALM

16 — you are my portion; the path of life is in your hand.



DAY 30

The First Candle

He brought me out also into a large place. He delivered me, because he delighted in me.

PSALM 18:19 (WEB)

Father Jakob, long ago, in Augsburg, lit one candle each morning for the people on his list. They say that by the end of his life the list was so long the candle never went out.

You have done thirty mornings. Nine knots named, handed over, kept loose. That is a month of your life given to this, and it is no small thing.

Some of the knots are looser, some are only named. Both count, in her book.

Light a candle today. Not for a result. For the fact. You came back thirty times.

Mary, Undoer of Knots, here is my first candle. Thirty mornings, nine knots, one small flame. I've named what hurt, and I've handed it to you. Keep it loose. Keep me coming back. Bring light into this house when I'm not looking. Bless every name on my page, the near and the far. I'll see you tomorrow. Amen.



TODAY

Light a candle and say aloud three names from your Names Page. Blow it out with an "Amen." Then set the book where you will find it tomorrow.

☐ DONE

What do I hope to find loosened when I come back to this page?

PSALM

18 — he brought me into a large place; the psalm for a month well begun.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

The knot you loosened can tie again. Nothing locks it shut except the habit of skipping. You opened a door this month. Come back tomorrow, and keep it from swinging shut.

LOOKING BACK: FOUR QUESTIONS

1. Which of the nine knots feels a little looser than thirty days ago? ☐

2. Which one did I avoid, and what was I afraid to find? ☐

3. What small habit did I keep, even on a tired morning? ☐

4. Whose name do I carry more gently now? ☐

A LETTER AT THE CLOSE OF THE MONTH

My friend,

You came back thirty times. Some mornings you were tired, and some mornings you were braver than you knew. Mary saw every one.

I want to be honest with you. A loosened knot can tie again. That is not failure. That is thread. The same hands that loosened it can loosen it a second time, and the third is easier.

So tomorrow, turn the page. We will leave the nine knots and go where the money is tight and the bills are real. It's a quieter kind of courage, and you already have it.

Go on. The coffee is still warm, and so is she.

Father Lucas





THE SEAL AND THE CANDLE OF THE MONTH

The Seal of Book 1: Nine Knots, held.
Date:

The Candle: "Nine Knots." Light a candle. Say three names from your Names Page. Blow it out with "Amen."



THIS CERTIFIES THAT

NAME

Nine Knots Held

Thirty mornings. Nine knots named and handed over. The first candle is lit.

DATE

Father Lucas

AUGSBURG

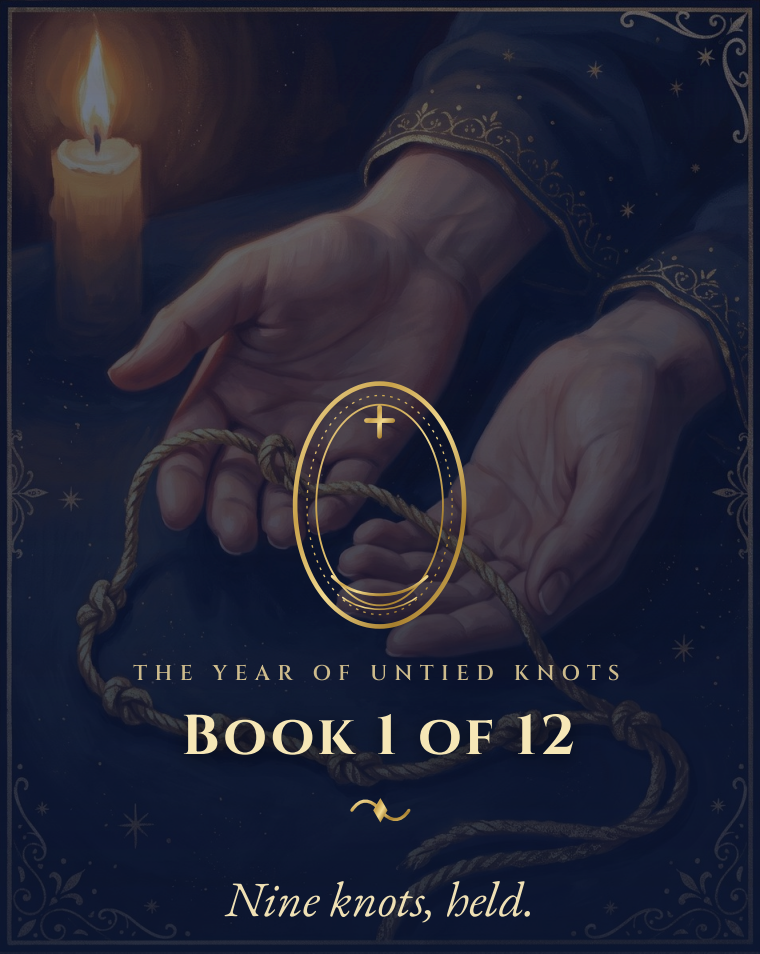
NOTES



What changed this month:

Names to add:

Turn to Book 2 tomorrow.



THE YEAR OF UNTIED KNOTS

Book 1 of 12

Nine knots, held.

NEXT · BOOK 2 · DAILY BREAD